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Investing in "Global Tech"

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Foreword

Dear Reader,

Welcome to our white paper on Investing in "Global Tech", where we explore the transformative trends shaping the global investment landscape over the coming years – and decades. We keep our spotlight throughout on the enduring appeal, and necessary evolution of **Global Tech**, which we define as tech and tech-enabled business models as represented by a growth benchmark index. We believe the theme is a core pillar of global asset allocation, representing around 20% of our CIO Foundation Balanced portfolio spanning tech and tech-enabled sectors expanding at an above average pace.

We are living in an era of extraordinary imagination. Rapid advances in generative AI have moved beyond being a purely structural theme to become a pervasive force – much as internet-enabled devices did in prior decades. While early signs of AI-driven disruption became evident as early as the first quarter of 2026, we remain firmly in the "glass half full" camp. In our view, AI presents far more opportunities than risks. The world has found a new growth engine – one capable of unlocking unprecedented investment opportunities – and this reinforces **Global Tech** as one of the key pillars in driving long-term portfolio returns.

Our back-testing shows that the Global Tech theme as represented by a growth benchmark index has historically been rewarding for investors, delivering consistent outperformance versus the other style, value. We see no reason for this to change. As innovation accelerates and competitive advantages widen, markets are likely to continue rewarding business models with superior and durable growth prospects.

Capturing these opportunities, however, requires a disciplined and systematic approach. Investing in tech and tech-enabled business models today goes beyond passive exposure; it demands active management to navigate market volatility, business cycles, and disruption risks. We address these dynamics through the **SCB framework to invest in Global Tech**, which identifies three broad opportunity sets and explicitly right-sizes exposure across them:

- **Structural opportunities (S):** Secular business models offering long-term visibility with strong compounding potential.
- **Cyclical opportunities (C):** Tactical opportunities arising from valuation mismatches and demand-supply imbalances as industries and regions embrace innovation at different speeds.
- **Binary opportunities (B):** Select turnaround as well as moonshot opportunities linked to next frontier technologies that offer optionality through an asymmetric risk-reward profile.

The future is arriving faster than ever. It is imperative that investors and leaders work hand in hand to embrace both the opportunities and challenges of this new era to forge a resilient and prosperous path forward. We hope this report provides the insights and framework needed to navigate what we believe is a rewarding – and defining – Global Tech investment landscape.

Samir Subberwal
Global Head, Wealth Solutions, Retail Products, Data & Analytics

The case to invest in Global Tech

Our Global Tech investment theme is firmly anchored in a growth style approach, where we place greater emphasis on tech and tech-enabled business models that can offer structural earnings growth prospects.

This does not imply that valuation is irrelevant for growth companies; rather, on a relative basis, earnings growth is the dominant driver of long-term market returns.

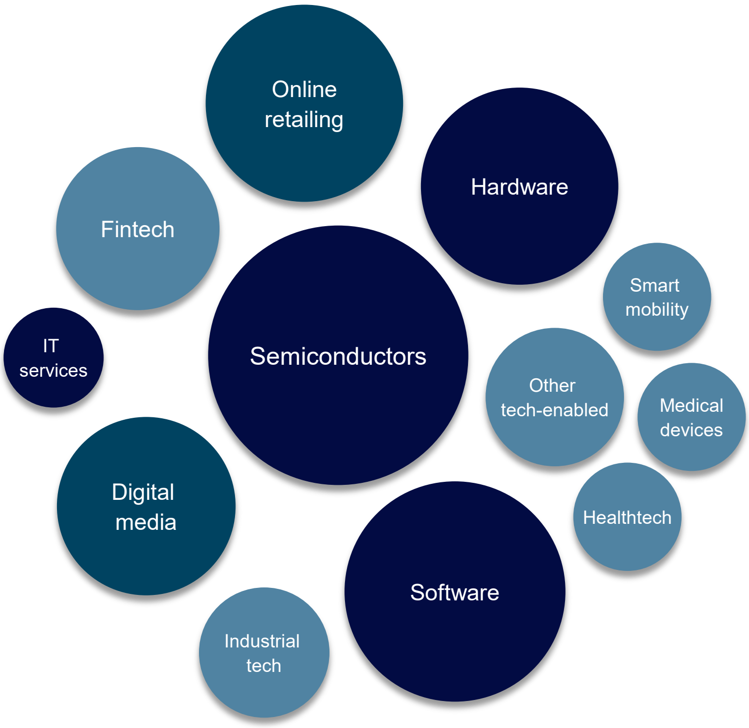
For us, Global Tech includes both tech and tech-enabled business models, which accounts for roughly 40% of global equities or put differently from an asset allocation point of view, the theme represents around 20% of our CIO Foundation Balanced portfolio. Relative to the other investment style—global value—our Global Tech theme is focused on growth companies operating in sectors that typically trade at valuation premiums. These premiums, in our view, are justified by above average and more durable growth prospects.

Companies within our Global Tech universe are predominantly found in tech and tech-enabled sectors such as IT, communication services, consumer discretionary, and industries such as fintech, healthtech etc. coupled with other innovation driven segments spanning both the new and old economy. A clear example is the renewed growth visibility in traditionally cyclical sectors such as industrials and utilities, supported by unprecedented AI related capital expenditure. Put simply, our Global Tech theme focuses on companies with tech and tech-enabled business models that can offer superior and sustainable growth trajectories.

Fig. 1

What is included in Global Tech?

Tech and Tech-enabled industries are spread across sectors with the size of bubble representing addressable market capitalisation in our view



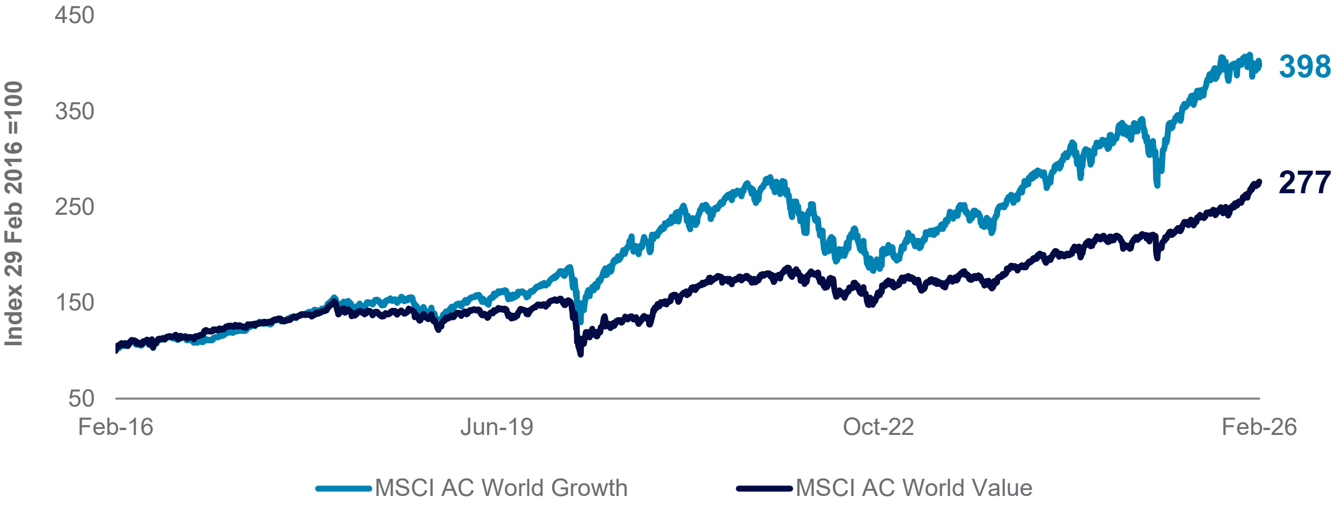
Source:Standard Chartered

From a performance perspective, Global Tech theme as represented by the growth benchmark index has delivered compelling results. Over the past decade (2016–2025), the theme generated average annual returns of 14.8%, compared with 10.7% for the value style (both based on MSCI indices). This outperformance has been driven primarily by superior earnings growth, typically in the low-to-mid-teens, while valuation premiums have remained broadly intact over the period.

Fig. 2

Despite premium valuations, Global Tech has outperformed global value over the past decade

MSCI AC World Growth vs Value index (rebased to 100, starting from close of 29 Feb 2016)



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Looking ahead, we believe the investment backdrop for Global Tech remains constructive. We expect strong revenue growth and resilient margin profiles to continue supporting superior earnings growth. While AI (artificial intelligence) will play a central role in expanding addressable markets for leading technology companies, innovation is far from confined to a single sector like IT. Areas such as consumer discretionary, digital media healthcare and fintech, that are represented across sectors, continue to see rapid product innovation and adoption, underpinning broad-based revenue momentum across our Global Tech universe. At the same time, steady margin trends – supported by pricing power, automation, and operational efficiencies – should sustain 10-15% earnings growth p.a. over the foreseeable future. Although near-term indicators capture only part of this picture, consensus earnings forecasts for 2026 and 2027 clearly show Global Tech-oriented sectors in the driver's seat.

Fig. 3

Superior earnings growth will likely support the performance of Global Tech

Earnings growth forecast for global sectors in 2026 and 2027

Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

While Global Tech continues to trade at a valuation premium relative to value, we believe this premium is warranted. On average, Global Tech offers 10-15% earnings growth p.a., compared with 6-9% earnings growth p.a. for global value counterparts – a differential that supports the valuation gap.

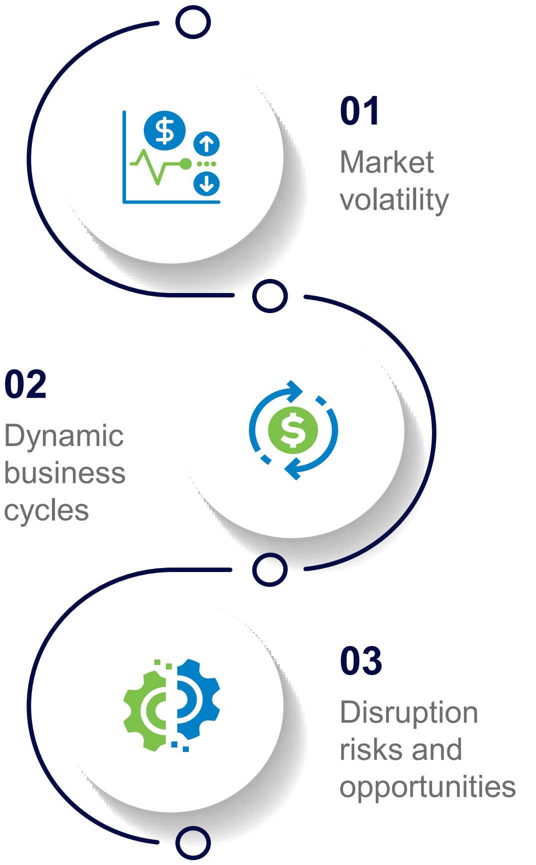
Against this backdrop, we see a favourable and durable backdrop for the Global Tech theme in the years ahead. Importantly, however, we believe the strongest case for outperformance lies in an active investment approach, rather than passive exposure. The dynamic and disruptive nature of once in a generation forces such as AI is likely to amplify market volatility, shorten business cycles, and drive disruption. Active management is therefore essential to navigate these shifts effectively – a topic we explore further in the next chapter.

Why active management in Global Tech is more rewarding?

While we maintain our conviction in the structural outperformance of Global Tech over value as a long-term theme, we see a more compelling risk-reward profile in adopting an active approach over passive investing.

This stems from the inherently dynamic nature of tech investing, where business models must continuously adapt to rapid innovation cycles. As the saying goes, “the only constant is change.” In this environment, actively rebalancing portfolios to reflect evolving fundamentals can help investors manage significant drawdowns while positioning for emerging opportunities at key inflection points.

Three key developments reinforce our case for active management in Global Tech:

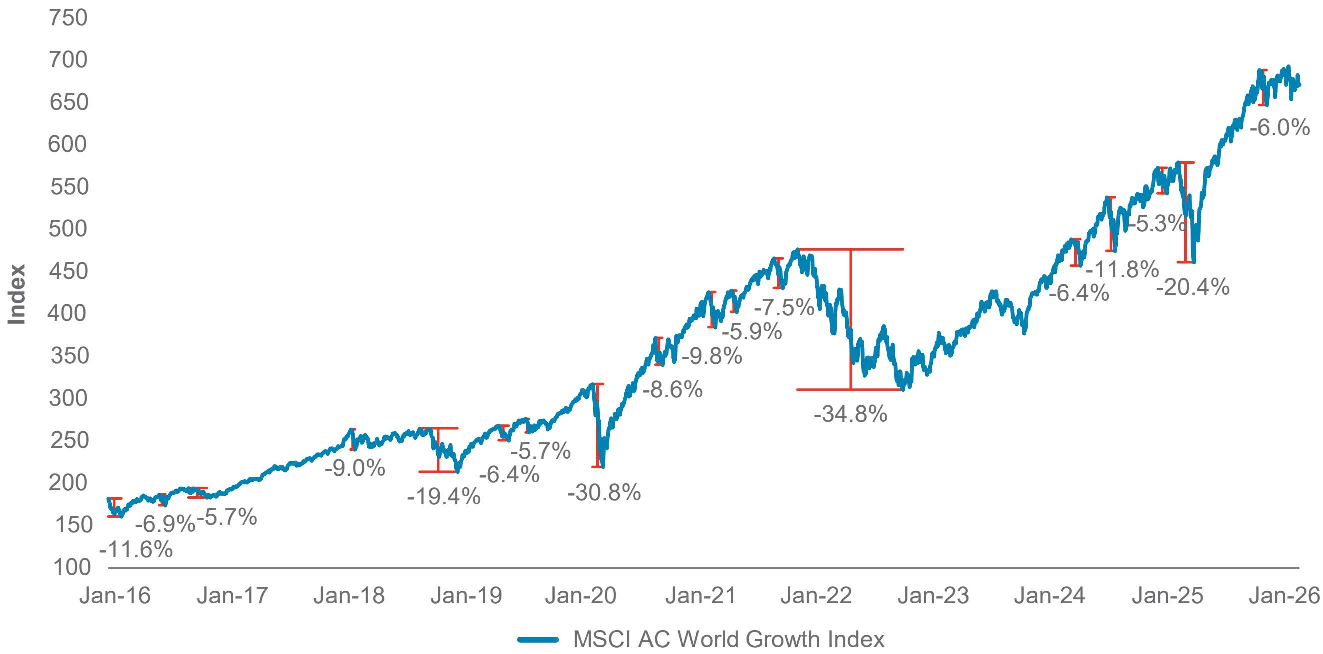


Let's begin with market volatility. Despite delivering above-average returns over the past decade, the Global Tech theme has experienced frequent drawdowns. This is not surprising given the innovative nature of its constituents, which are often exposed to idiosyncratic risks such as regulatory shifts, product cycles, leadership changes, or supply chain disruptions. Fig. 4, shows the number of 5% and above drawdowns for Global Tech, as represented by growth benchmark index over the past decade.

Fig. 4

Global Tech theme experienced multiple drawdowns over the past decade

Drawdowns of at least 5% for MSCI AC World Growth Index between 2016-2025



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

However, these drawdowns have historically presented attractive entry points and not reasons to panic. As shown in Fig. 5, the Global Tech as represented by growth benchmark index has consistently rebounded strongly over the subsequent 6 months after frequent drawdowns. This underscores the value of an active approach – one that distinguishes between short-term noise and long-term fundamentals, enabling investors to capitalise on volatility rather than be derailed by it.

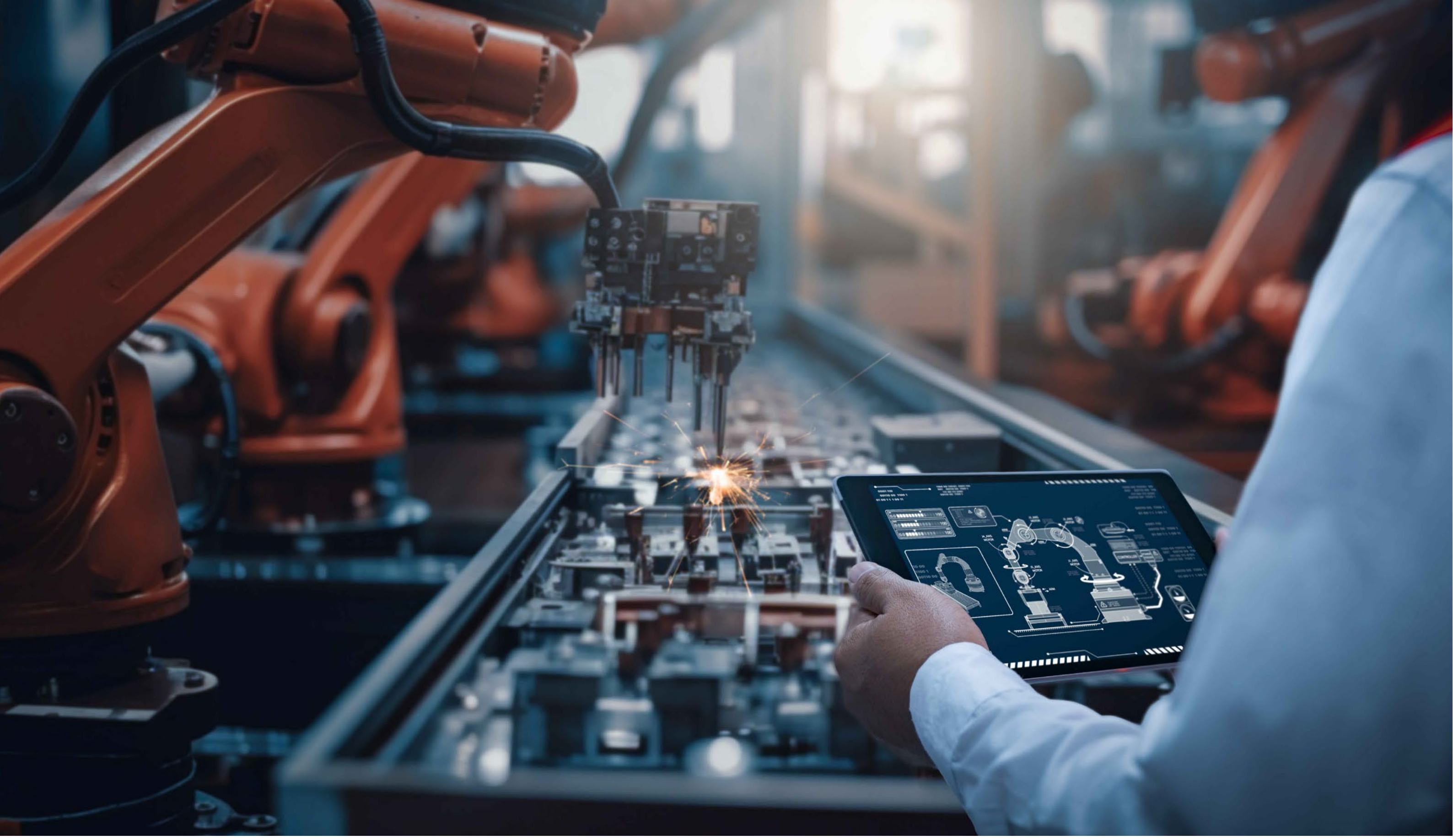
Fig. 5

Global Tech stocks rebounded historically after a sharp decline

6-month rebound in MSCI AC World Growth Index after frequent drawdowns over the past decade

Peak	Trough	Days (Peak to Trough)	6m return after the trough
01 Jan 2016	11 Feb 2016	41	20.4%
08 Jun 2016	27 Jun 2016	19	8.3%
07 Sep 2016	04 Nov2016	58	15.5%
26 Jan 2018	08 Feb 2018	13	8.5%
29 Aug 2018	25 Dec 2018	118	25.2%
03 May 2019	03 Jun 2019	31	13.4%
26 Jul 2019	05 Aug 2019	10	19.2%
19 Feb 2020	23 Mar 2020	33	55.5%
02 Sep 2020	24 Sept 2020	22	15.5%
15 Feb 2021	08 Mar2021	21	20.5%
26 Apr 2021	13 May 2021	17	17.3%
07 Sep 2021	04 Oct 2021	27	-0.5%
19 Nov 2021	14 Oct 2022	329	22.7%
21 Mar 2024	19 Apr 2024	29	18.4%
10 Jul 2024	05 Aug 2024	26	19.4%
16 Dec 2024	14 Jan 2025	29	11.5%
18 Feb 2025	08 Apr 2025	49	45.1%
29 Oct 2025	21 Nov 2025	23	–
		Average	**19.8%**

Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

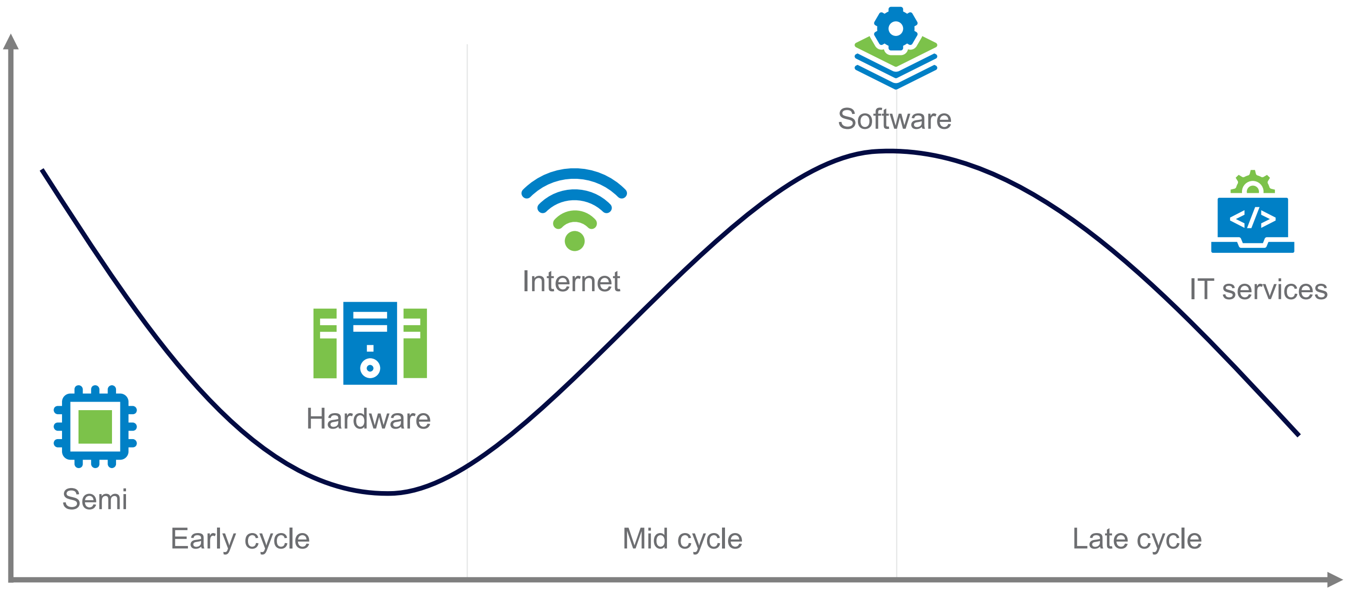


The second pillar of our argument is the importance of navigating business cycles within Global Tech's diverse segments. For instance, within the tech sector, five key industries – semiconductors, hardware, internet, software, and IT services – tend to perform differently depending on the stage of the business cycle. Our "Tech Industry Playbook" (see Fig. 6) shows that semiconductors and hardware typically lead in early-cycle recoveries, followed by internet and software in the mid-cycle, and IT services in the late cycle.

Fig. 6

Tech Industry Playbook to navigate across the business cycle

Positioning across five industries based on the business cycle is key to generate alpha



Source: Standard Chartered

Against this backdrop, active approaches that can correctly identify the business cycle and apply industry playbooks—by overweighting or underweighting specific sub-segments—can help generate alpha. For instance, the Tech industry playbook is also working effectively even during the ongoing AI cycle. With AI still in its early innings, semiconductors and internet companies have outperformed, while software and IT services – typically mid-to-late cycle beneficiaries – have lagged. We believe playbooks such as these remain valuable tools for identifying inflection points and adjusting allocations accordingly. It is also worth noting that tech sub-cycles vary in duration, requiring nimble positioning.

Lastly, active management is essential in navigating disruption risks – an inherent feature of the Global Tech theme. As discussed earlier, innovation is both a driver and a disruptor for the theme. Understanding evolving business models and proactively managing disruption risk can help investors stay focused and avoid emotionally driven decisions. For example, Fig. 7 compares the 10-year performance of retail companies, Amazon and Walmart. While both companies delivered largely similar returns over the full period, the journey was markedly different. In the first half, online retailer Amazon's dominance in e-commerce weighed heavily on traditional retailers like Walmart. However, as incumbents adapted and embraced digital transformation, they regained investor confidence and narrowed the performance gap eventually. Understanding at which stage of the disruption cycle and active adjustment of portfolios is also key to generate alpha within the Global Tech theme.

Fig. 7

Case study: Amazon and Walmart share prices evolved at different paces

Amazon and Walmart (rebased to 100, starting from close of 29 Feb 16)

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

To summarise, we believe that active management is not just preferable but essential when investing in the dynamic Global Tech theme. By actively managing volatility, navigating sector and industry cycles, and managing disruption risks, investors can enhance returns and mitigate downside risks more effectively than through a passive approach.

The SCB framework to invest in Global Tech

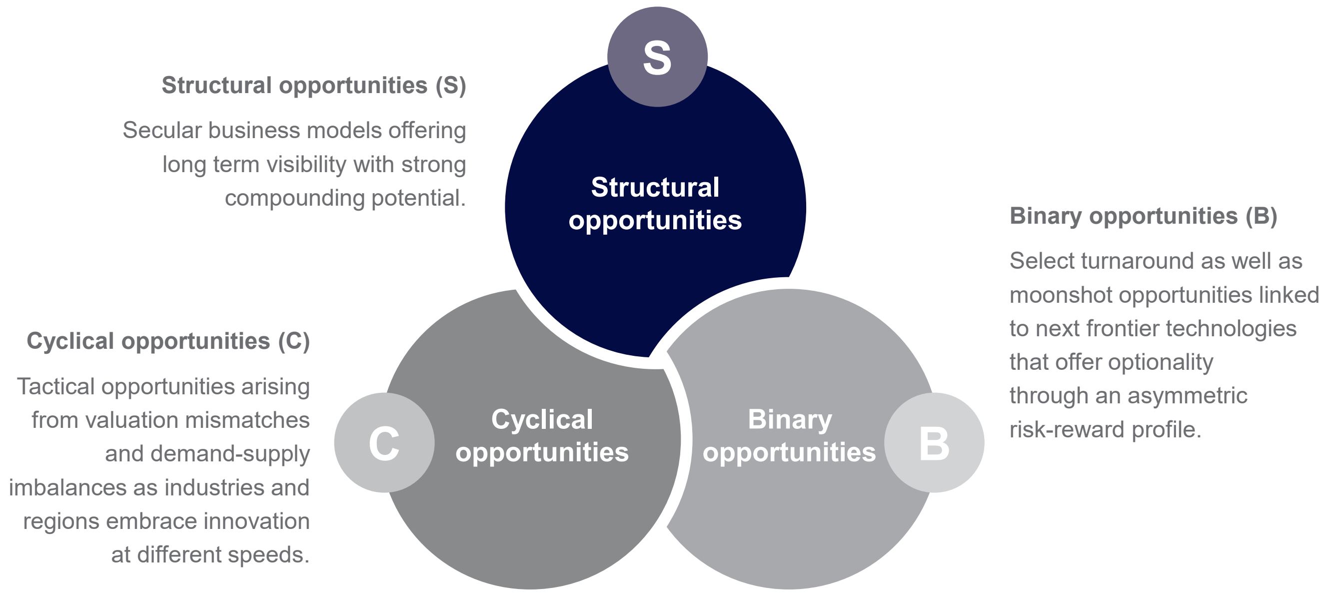
With active management chosen as the preferred approach to investing in Global Tech, how should investors select the right business models within a portfolio context?

This is a fair question, given that most companies in the Global Tech universe typically report above average earnings growth, so there needs to be some form of differentiation. As a result, it becomes imperative not only to segment companies into distinct buckets, but also to right-size exposures from a portfolio construction perspective.

To help investors navigate this challenge, we introduce the **SCB framework** for investing in Global Tech. Under this framework, Global Tech companies are categorised into three buckets: **Structural opportunities (S), Cyclical opportunities (C) and Binary opportunities (B).**

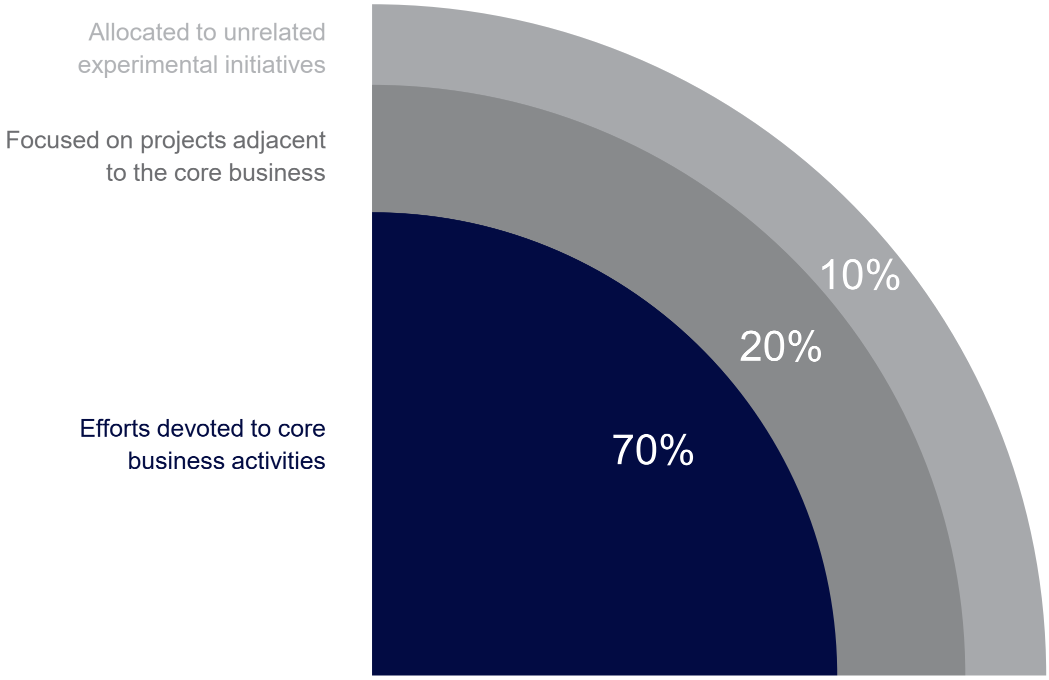
Fig. 8

The SCB framework to invest in Global Tech



Source: Standard Chartered

In thinking about how to right size these three buckets, we draw inspiration from the 70-20-10 rule of innovation, popularised by Google, which seeks to optimise resource allocation as follows:



In a similar spirit, we believe the **70-20-10 rule** is well suited to Global Tech portfolios. While our intention is not to rigidly define or constrain portfolio allocations to precise limits, the underlying principles provide a useful framework for investors. By embracing flexibility rather than strict thresholds, we see greater scope for alpha generation, particularly when this framework is combined with complementary approaches.

For example, overlaying the **70-20-10 innovation framework** with our **Tech Industry Playbook** allows investors to right size positions across segments. Within semiconductors, logic and foundry can be viewed as **structural** exposures, memory as **cyclical**, and areas such as quantum computing as **binary** opportunities. Similarly, within software, horizontal software companies tend to be **structural**, vertical software companies more **cyclical**, and emerging agentic software companies, mostly **binary** in nature.

Against this backdrop, without being overly rigid and by applying the 70-20-10 rule in spirit, we believe that **approximately 70% of a Global Tech** portfolio can be allocated to **Structural opportunities**. The objective of this bucket is to defend the portfolio while compounding returns through companies with proven business models, strong margins, robust cash flow generation and sound corporate governance. Examples include platform companies with dominant industry positions across technology, healthcare and fintech. Given the compounding objective, the investment horizon for structural opportunities should be long-term.

Approximately **20% allocation** in our view should be directed towards **Cyclical opportunities** – companies benefiting from strong cyclical tailwinds driven by near-term valuation mismatches or demand supply imbalances. Unlike structural opportunities, these companies are often product centric (rather than platform based) or tier 2 players within their respective industries. As the primary objective is to capture near-term value, the investment horizon for cyclical opportunities is typically shorter, often **less than one year.**

Finally, roughly remaining **10% allocation** should, in our view, be reserved for **Binary opportunities** that offer asymmetric risk-reward profiles. These include potential turnarounds within fallen angels as well as investments in frontier or moonshot technologies that may not yet be commercially viable but possess the potential for exponential growth. Turnaround opportunities can emerge across market capitalisation segments and are typically driven by the prospect of structural mean reversion. Moonshot opportunities may include areas such as space technologies, neural interfaces, autonomous driving and quantum computing. While the investment horizon in this bucket is less prescriptive given the primary objective is to unlock asymmetric risk-reward profiles, disciplined risk management – such as the use of strict stop loss frameworks – is critical here.

In conclusion, we believe that a clear understanding of business models, effective segmentation into the right opportunity buckets, and disciplined right sizing of allocations are essential to generating **sustainable alpha** within Global Tech portfolios.

Staying the course and conclusions

With active management in place and the SCB framework guiding our approach to Global Tech, the next obvious question is whether investors should be mindful of additional idiosyncrasies when investing in the theme.

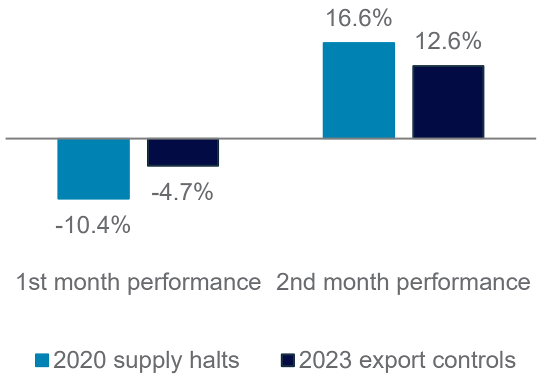
Given the dynamic news flow and the many innovative forces shaping Global Tech, investors require subject matter expertise to navigate the space effectively and generate alpha. As such, we believe professional managers are well equipped to actively manage Global Tech portfolios, particularly as they are better positioned to manage the behavioural aspects of investing in volatile segments such as tech or tech-enabled business models. The key is to stay invested, avoid being swayed by short-term volatility, and not be driven by emotional decision making – areas where professional managers can add meaningful value.

Take, for example, frequent supply chain disruptions in tech business models. A typical investor response is often to sell affected stocks, whereas a professional manager with a deeper understanding of supply chains and their many moving parts is less likely to overreact. As illustrated in the figure on the right, while the Global Tech theme initially suffered during the first month of supply disruptions, it rebounded strongly in the second month as risks appeared manageable. Remaining invested throughout, rather than selling low and buying back higher, would have been the more effective approach.

Fig. 9

Global Tech's performance during recent supply chain disruptions

First and second month performance of MSCI AC World Growth after 2020 supply halts and 2023 export controls



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

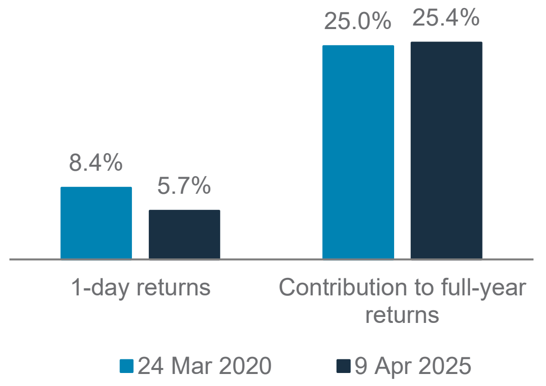
Another illustration of why staying invested matters can be seen in Fig. 10, which highlights the two best single day returns for the Global Tech theme over the past decade. Notably, these two days accounted for nearly 25% of the full year returns in their respective years. What is particularly striking is that these gains were generated during periods of heightened uncertainty (around peak COVID related stress in 2020 and around Liberation Day in 2025). Once again, this reinforces the importance of staying invested, and our view that professional managers are better equipped to navigate such environments.

Staying invested does not mean ignoring risks – this is not our message. Rather, we believe robust risk management is essential to preparing for both idiosyncratic risks, such as innovation, disruption, management changes and supply chain challenges, as well as systemic risks related to inflation, interest rates and geopolitics. For instance, Global Tech underperformed value in 2022 amid rising interest rates and heightened geopolitical tensions. However, the emergence of the ChatGPT app and generative AI use cases towards the end of that year reaffirmed that innovation remains firmly in the driving seat.

Fig. 10

The case for staying invested in Global Tech

Two best daily returns for Global Tech over the past decade accounted for roughly a quarter of that year's total returns



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

In summary, with Global Tech a key pillar of global asset allocation, representing around 20% of the CIO Foundation portfolio, investors must recognise the strategic importance of the theme and avoid complacency at a time when disruptive technologies such as AI are fundamentally reshaping the investment landscape. We believe that active management – anchored by clear frameworks and a disciplined commitment to staying invested – can make Global Tech a highly rewarding long-term opportunity. Over time, investors stand to benefit from the compounding power of business models with above average and durable growth prospects.

For more details on how to invest in Global Tech, please contact your Standard Chartered representative.

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InvesTips

Redefining wealth through health and wellness

March 2026

WS Global CIO Office

The link between longevity, mental health and wealth outcomes has become clearer than ever before. Most investors focus solely on financial aspects, but studies suggest that a holistic approach, combining financial resilience, environmental harmony and physical/mental well-being, allows investors to build wealth that supports sustained, long-term success.

Steve Brice
Global Chief Investment Officer

Manpreet Gill
Chief Investment Officer, Africa, Middle East & Europe (AMEE)

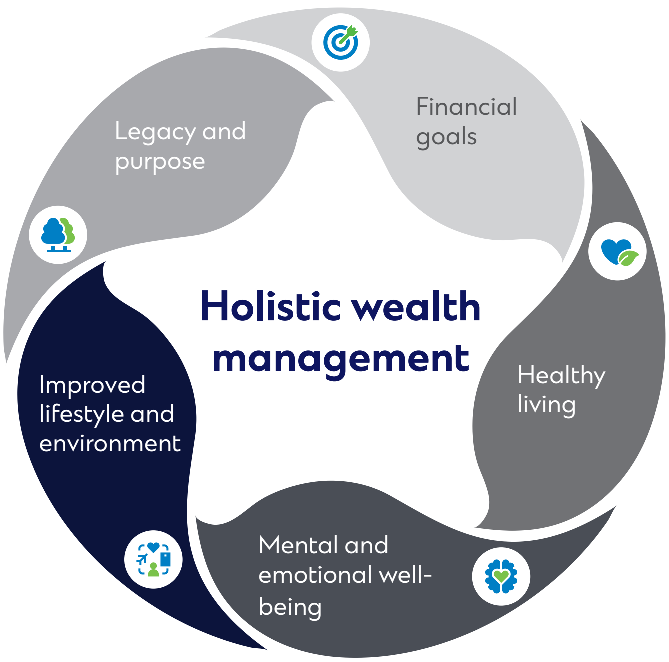
This report explores the nuances of holistic, health- and wellness-centred wealth management and financial planning, including how these elements can be woven into wealth goals and the emerging trends shaping this approach.

Understanding holistic wealth management

Holistic wealth management is more than just portfolio performance and asset growth. It focuses on an investor's overall well-being by integrating financial health with physical, mental and emotional wellness.

This integrated approach ensures your wealth journey will not only support your financial aspirations but will also ensure you lead a fulfilling, resilient and purpose-driven life. This approach incorporates:

- **Comprehensive healthcare cost planning**, including emergency funds, insurance, long-term care considerations and medical directives
- **Stress-aware financial planning** that accounts for emotional triggers and behavioural biases (guardrails) while incorporating a structured decision-making framework that supports bias-free investing and ensures adequate risk preparedness
- **Preventive health strategies** and longevity planning
- Access to wellness services and **wellness-centric living environments** to support healthier lifestyles
- Wealth decisions aligned with **personal lifestyle goals**,including eco-conscious living, cross-border investing and travel
- **Family harmony and communication frameworks** for estate planning and business succession

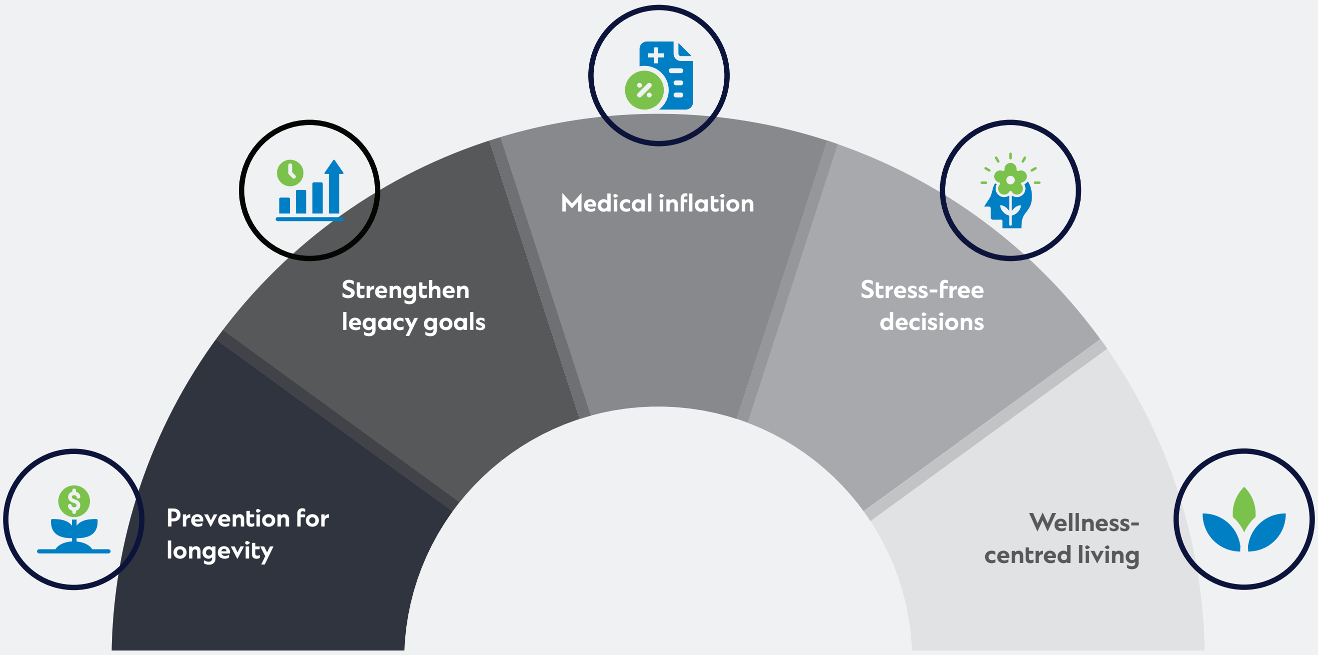


Source: Standard Chartered

Importance of health and wellness in wealth strategy

Wealth strategies that overlook health and well-being can often invite several challenges. For instance, an investor's long-term financial goals could be derailed if a sudden illness or unexpected medical emergency leads to a loss of income.

Why integrate health and wellness into financial decision-making?



Source: Standard Chartered

There are several strong reasons to include health and wellness as part of your broader wealth management strategy:

Healthcare costs are unpredictable, inflationary and rising
According to WTW's 2026 Global Medical Trends Survey Report, medical costs rose by 10.4% in 2025, continuing a double-digit trend. A majority of global insurers expect medical costs to trend higher over the next three years. Moreover, public healthcare systems are overwhelmed, necessitating investors to avail private insurance to lower out-of-pocket expenses. Unexpected medical events can erode your savings, weaken your long-term wealth strategy or trigger debt.

Mental and emotional health swings can influence financial decisions

Nearly 90% of our financial decisions are based on emotions. Studies further indicate that analytical capabilities get compromised when an individual is emotionally distressed or cognitively overwhelmed. This could trigger impulsive financial decisions, overreaction to market swings, panic selling, timing mistakes and overspending. Many investors experience intense performance pressure, owing to the responsibility of managing family wealth and burnout from work or business obligations, leading to cognitive overload and emotional distress.

Preventive health measures can influence longevity and health spans

Early screenings, vaccinations and proactive stress management shape longevity and health spans. An American College of Cardiology study found that individuals who followed healthy lifestyle and dietary habits had about a 90% lower risk of heart attacks and around a 75% lower risk of developing type-2 diabetes. Investors are turning to personalised biomarker panels and digital wellness gadgets/platforms as part of preventive health measures. In essence, preventive healthcare not only helps avoid disease but also protects 'human capital' and extends wealth accumulation years.

Strategies to integrate health planning into wealth management

Several studies have found that emotionally resilient individuals – often built thorough proactive stress management – engaged more in multi-generational financial discussions. The Milken Institute also noted that wealthy individuals who prioritised preventive healthcare not only had a better quality of life but also bolstered their wealth journey.

Investors who track their wellness metrics are more likely to stay invested in long-range financial plans.
Here are some key strategies that investors can consider:

Health emergency buffers

Health emergency buffers act as a bridge between medical care and wealth by creating liquid capital that helps investors stay resilient during health shocks without compromising on long-term financial objectives. Preparedness for unforeseen medical events can prevent spirals of anxiety or forced portfolio liquidation. The need for sufficient healthcare emergency funds is also necessitated by the public healthcare systems being overwhelmed and exposing investors to such systems strain. In Asia, out-of-pocket spending remains elevated, and households shoulder around 40% of total health expenditure. A single medical emergency could disproportionately slow down wealth accumulation.

Insurance

A financial arrangement where you pay a premium to an insurer in exchange for protection against specific losses, is a common risk-transfer tool. Global premiums were valued over USD 7trn in 2024 across health, life and property and casualty (P&C) insurance. Different types of insurance cater to different risks and life goals:

Health insurance offers protection against any unforeseen medical shocks owing to illness or injury. It generally covers hospitalisation, medical expenses and ongoing treatment, helping individuals avoid out-of-pocket expenses. Health insurance is also a **wealth protection tool**, as it prevents financial shocks, ensures long-term earning capacity and allows disciplined financial planning.

- **International medical insurance** is ideal for globally mobile individuals and families. It provides seamless access to medical care across borders, often including hospitalisation, chronic condition management, emergency services and preventive care.
- **Integrated wellness insurance models** provide support across the entire health continuum – prevention, diagnosis, treatment, after-care and wellness coaching. They offer healthcare coordination, support long-term medical conditions and provide mental and emotional wellness support. These models also offer differentiated services such as priority access to specialists, second-medical-opinion services, personalised case management and high-touch medical concierge support that streamline health journeys and elevate outcomes.

- The health insurance landscape is undergoing a massive shift, with an emphasis on **holistic partnerships** driven by digital health trackers and wellness ecosystems. Many insurers partner with providers of healthtech devices and **wearables** to provide tailored health insights across the entire health lifecycle. In a sense, health insurance is transforming from a reimbursement product into an ongoing, tech-enabled wellness partner. This creates a win-win for both the insurer and insured, reducing premiums for the insured and lowering long-term claims for the insurance companies. Moreover, globally mobile individuals and families can benefit from priority access to global centres of medical excellence and cross-border care coordination.

Traditional health insurance vs integrated wellness insurance

Aspect	Traditional health insurance	Integrated wellness insurance
Approach	Reactive, claims driven	Proactive, continuous health management
Coverage	Hospitalisation, surgeries, recovery and eligible treatments	Medical cover, preventive care, mental health and after care services
Technology integration	Basic telehealth, limited wellness tools	Wearables, health analytics, telehealth and personalised coaching
Financial impact	Protects against high medical bills	Reduces long term healthcare costs, lowers claims and improves risk profile
Mental well-being support	Usually minimal or limited	Includes mental health and well-being support
Ideal for	Standard protection against health risks	Holistic health optimisation and long term well-being

Source: Standard Chartered

Life insurance hedges life risk. Beyond guaranteed payouts to beneficiaries upon the death of a policyholder, it provides emotional security and reduces anxiety because dependents are protected. Life insurance supports a person's wealth journey by **combining risk protection with disciplined, long-horizon savings**. Several modern-day policies integrate investment-linked solutions with protection to help investors accumulate wealth, while securing guaranteed benefits for their families. Life insurance solutions are also valuable tools in **estate planning**; they provide liquidity to cover for taxes and debt without the need to liquidate estate.

Property and casualty (P&C) insurance protects assets (property) and covers against liabilities (casualty), reducing anxiety and creating a 'peace-of-mind' effect. Although P&C insurance is often seen only as a basic protection tool, it is a critical health and wealth preservation technique. It **shields your assets, including houses and businesses**, from losses that can wipe out years of savings and derail long-term plans. With small, predictable premium payments, unpredictable, high-loss events can be hedged to support stable cash flow and long-term wealth preservation.

Insurance, in any form, reduces volatility and improves investors' financial resilience.

Preventive health strategies

Preventive health strategies can mitigate health risks while also reframing the approach to wealth. A McKinsey Health Institute paper found that investors who consider proactive wellness and health strategies tend to be more confident in financial/legacy planning:

- Advanced technologies such as predictive analytics, next-gen genomic sequencing and IoT-enabled wearables are leading the transformation **from a reactive to a proactive** approach towards healthcare. **Genomic testing** identifies health risks and predicts disease likelihood, guiding early diagnosis. **Wearables** deliver real-time data for continuous monitoring, early detection and personalised preventive care. These approaches can support precision medicine, better physical activity, cardiovascular health and diabetes management.
- Organisations are including **preventive programmes** as they can reduce healthcare costs and claims significantly. For example, Cleveland Clinic's employee wellness initiative saved its healthcare system approximately USD 180m by enabling employees to reach eight preventive health targets (including stress management, healthy BMI and annual primary-care visits). Savings free up more capital for long-term goals such as retirement and investments.
- Proactive health and wellness strategies help to protect the primary wealth engine, i.e., **human capital**. The Cleveland Clinic study also showed that healthy individuals could reduce their chronic-disease risk by nearly 90% through preventive strategies, thereby strengthening their long-term capacity to work. **Career longevity** could translate to higher earnings and preserve income streams.
- With reduced risk profiles owing to preventive care, investors generally pay lower premiums and premium increases are slower. A study indicated that individuals under preventive care programmes are able to reduce premiums roughly worth USD 1,600 per family. This **reduced cash outflow** helps households maintain steady investing habits.

Wellness-centred living

Wellness-centred living refers to homes, communities and neighbourhoods that are intentionally designed to support physical, mental and emotional well-being. **Clean air, natural light, low toxicity and noise, and an active lifestyle** are some key features of such health environments. The Global Wellness Institute (GWI) identifies wellness-centred communities as the next frontier of growth for the wellness industry. Wellness real estate has been growing at 19.5% annually, nearly 4x faster than traditional real estate.

GWI assessed clinical and building-environment data and found that improved health environments contributed to better health outcomes. Buyers are increasingly seeking **sustainable and health-forward environments**, a trend that supports premium willingness-to-pay for homes with superior air quality, natural light and biophilic design. Growing buyer preference, faster absorption and category outperformance indicate that wellness properties tend to hold value better and have better liquidity than traditional properties.

It’s time for an integrated approach

All the available data points to the fact that investors are increasingly recognising health and wellness as key components of holistic wealth management. This has resulted in systemic shifts in the financial planning and investing landscape. Homes with clear air, natural light, low toxicity and green access are being pursued for their potential to contribute to overall wellness and financial stability. Insurance is seeing an evident shift from being a claims-driven coverage to offering preventive care, mental and emotional support, telemedicine access and health analytics, which enables tailored advice and risk management. Wearables and real time health data are helping improve investors’ overall well-being and financial behaviour.

As the link between wealth and health strengthens, investors who follow a holistic and integrated approach are likely to build the most resilient portfolios.

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Redefining wealth through health and wellness

March 2026

WS Global CIO Office

The link between longevity, mental health and wealth outcomes has become clearer than ever before. Most investors focus solely on financial aspects, but studies suggest that a holistic approach, combining financial resilience, environmental harmony and physical/mental well-being, allows investors to build wealth that supports sustained, long-term success.

Steve Brice
Global Chief Investment Officer

Manpreet Gill
Chief Investment Officer, Africa, Middle East & Europe (AMEE)

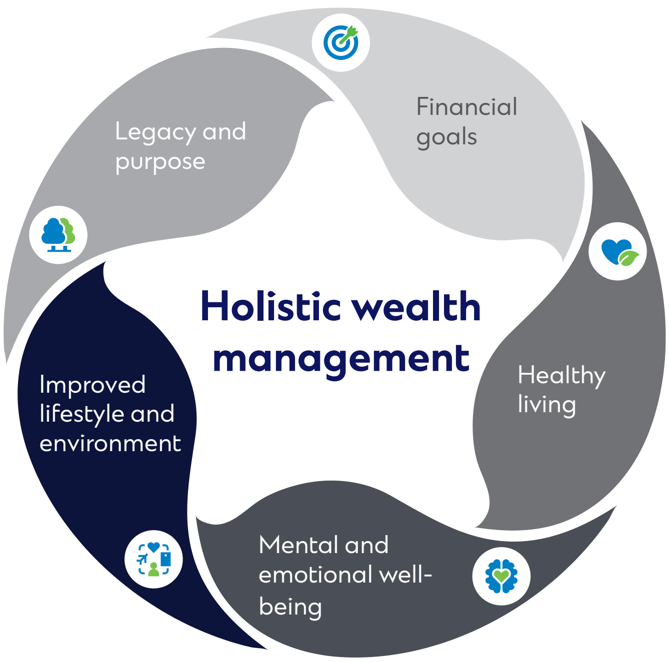
This report explores the nuances of holistic, health- and wellness-centred wealth management and financial planning, including how these elements can be woven into wealth goals and the emerging trends shaping this approach.

Understanding holistic wealth management

Holistic wealth management is more than just portfolio performance and asset growth. It focuses on an investor's overall well-being by integrating financial health with physical, mental and emotional wellness.

This integrated approach ensures your wealth journey will not only support your financial aspirations but will also ensure you lead a fulfilling, resilient and purpose-driven life. This approach incorporates:

- **Comprehensive healthcare cost planning**, including emergency funds, insurance, long-term care considerations and medical directives
- **Stress-aware financial planning** that accounts for emotional triggers and behavioural biases (guardrails) while incorporating a structured decision-making framework that supports bias-free investing and ensures adequate risk preparedness
- **Preventive health strategies** and longevity planning
- Access to wellness services and **wellness-centric living environments** to support healthier lifestyles
- Wealth decisions aligned with **personal lifestyle goals**,including eco-conscious living, cross-border investing and travel
- **Family harmony and communication frameworks** for estate planning and business succession

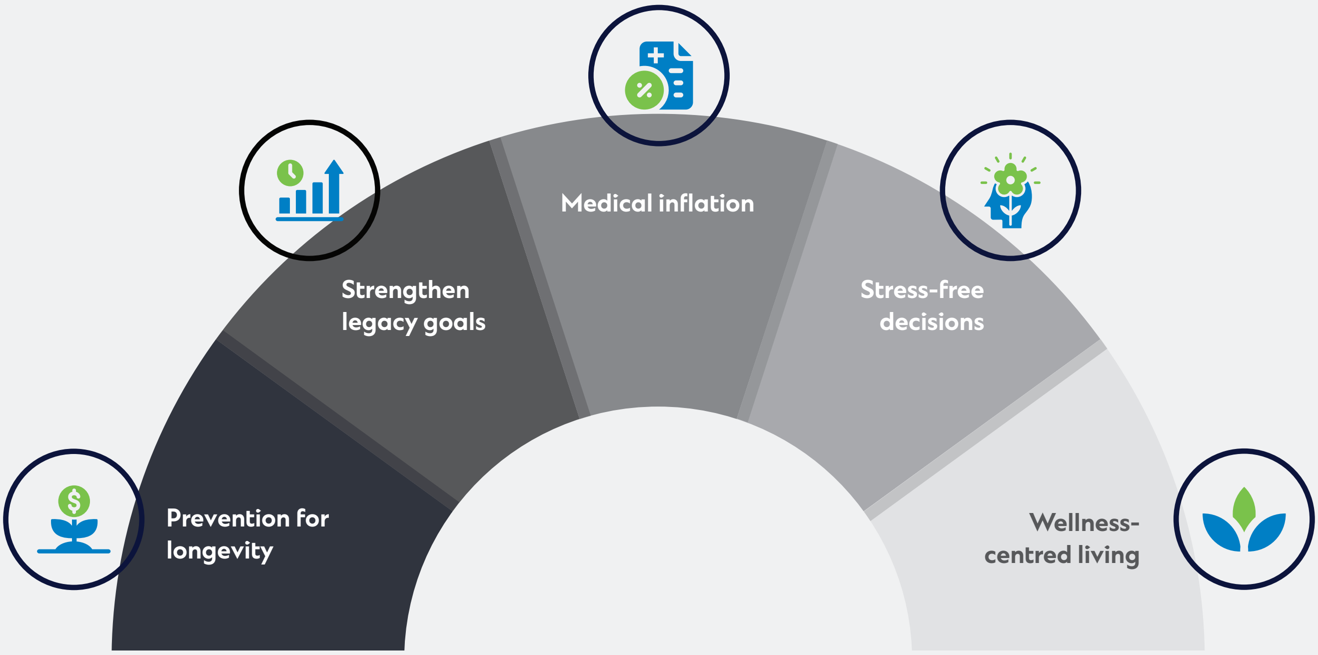


Source: Standard Chartered

Importance of health and wellness in wealth strategy

Wealth strategies that overlook health and well-being can often invite several challenges. For instance, an investor's long-term financial goals could be derailed if a sudden illness or unexpected medical emergency leads to a loss of income.

Why integrate health and wellness into financial decision-making?



Source: Standard Chartered

There are several strong reasons to include health and wellness as part of your broader wealth management strategy:

Healthcare costs are unpredictable, inflationary and rising

According to WTW's 2026 Global Medical Trends Survey Report, medical costs rose by 10.4% in 2025, continuing a double-digit trend. A majority of global insurers expect medical costs to trend higher over the next three years. Moreover, public healthcare systems are overwhelmed, necessitating investors to avail private insurance to lower out-of-pocket expenses. Unexpected medical events can erode your savings, weaken your long-term wealth strategy or trigger debt.

Mental and emotional health swings can influence financial decisions
Nearly 90% of our financial decisions are based on emotions. Studies further indicate that analytical capabilities get compromised when an individual is emotionally distressed or cognitively overwhelmed. This could trigger impulsive financial decisions, overreaction to market swings, panic selling, timing mistakes and overspending. Many investors experience intense performance pressure, owing to the responsibility of managing family wealth and burnout from work or business obligations, leading to cognitive overload and emotional distress.

Preventive health measures can influence longevity and health spans
Early screenings, vaccinations and proactive stress management shape longevity and health spans. An American College of Cardiology study found that individuals who followed healthy lifestyle and dietary habits had about a 90% lower risk of heart attacks and around a 75% lower risk of developing type-2 diabetes. Investors are turning to personalised biomarker panels and digital wellness gadgets/platforms as part of preventive health measures. In essence, preventive healthcare not only helps avoid disease but also protects 'human capital' and extends wealth accumulation years.

Strategies to integrate health planning into wealth management

Several studies have found that emotionally resilient individuals – often built thorough proactive stress management – engaged more in multi-generational financial discussions. The Milken Institute also noted that wealthy individuals who prioritised preventive healthcare not only had a better quality of life but also bolstered their wealth journey.

Investors who track their wellness metrics are more likely to stay invested in long-range financial plans.
Here are some key strategies that investors can consider:

Health emergency buffers

Health emergency buffers act as a bridge between medical care and wealth by creating liquid capital that helps investors stay resilient during health shocks without compromising on long-term financial objectives. Preparedness for unforeseen medical events can prevent spirals of anxiety or forced portfolio liquidation. The need for sufficient healthcare emergency funds is also necessitated by the public healthcare systems being overwhelmed and exposing investors to such systems strain. In Asia, out-of-pocket spending remains elevated, and households shoulder around 40% of total health expenditure. A single medical emergency could disproportionately slow down wealth accumulation.

Insurance

A financial arrangement where you pay a premium to an insurer in exchange for protection against specific losses, is a common risk-transfer tool. Global premiums were valued over USD 7trn in 2024 across health, life and property and casualty (P&C) insurance. Different types of insurance cater to different risks and life goals:

Health insurance offers protection against any unforeseen medical shocks owing to illness or injury. It generally covers hospitalisation, medical expenses and ongoing treatment, helping individuals avoid out-of-pocket expenses. Health insurance is also a **wealth protection tool**, as it prevents financial shocks, ensures long-term earning capacity and allows disciplined financial planning.

- **International medical insurance** is ideal for globally mobile individuals and families. It provides seamless access to medical care across borders, often including hospitalisation, chronic condition management, emergency services and preventive care.
- **Integrated wellness insurance models** provide support across the entire health continuum – prevention, diagnosis, treatment, after-care and wellness coaching. They offer healthcare coordination, support long-term medical conditions and provide mental and emotional wellness support. These models also offer differentiated services such as priority access to specialists, second-medical-opinion services, personalised case management and high-touch medical concierge support that streamline health journeys and elevate outcomes.

- The health insurance landscape is undergoing a massive shift, with an emphasis on **holistic partnerships** driven by digital health trackers and wellness ecosystems. Many insurers partner with providers of healthtech devices and **wearables** to provide tailored health insights across the entire health lifecycle. In a sense, health insurance is transforming from a reimbursement product into an ongoing, tech-enabled wellness partner. This creates a win-win for both the insurer and insured, reducing premiums for the insured and lowering long-term claims for the insurance companies. Moreover, globally mobile individuals and families can benefit from priority access to global centres of medical excellence and cross-border care coordination.

Traditional health insurance vs integrated wellness insurance

Aspect	Traditional health insurance	Integrated wellness insurance
Approach	Reactive, claims driven	Proactive, continuous health management
Coverage	Hospitalisation, surgeries, recovery and eligible treatments	Medical cover, preventive care, mental health and after care services
Technology integration	Basic telehealth, limited wellness tools	Wearables, health analytics, telehealth and personalised coaching
Financial impact	Protects against high medical bills	Reduces long term healthcare costs, lowers claims and improves risk profile
Mental well-being support	Usually minimal or limited	Includes mental health and well-being support
Ideal for	Standard protection against health risks	Holistic health optimisation and long term well-being

Source: Standard Chartered

Life insurance hedges life risk. Beyond guaranteed payouts to beneficiaries upon the death of a policyholder, it provides emotional security and reduces anxiety because dependents are protected. Life insurance supports a person's wealth journey by **combining risk protection with disciplined, long-horizon savings**. Several modern-day policies integrate investment-linked solutions with protection to help investors accumulate wealth, while securing guaranteed benefits for their families. Life insurance solutions are also valuable tools in **estate planning**; they provide liquidity to cover for taxes and debt without the need to liquidate estate.

Property and casualty (P&C) insurance protects assets (property) and covers against liabilities (casualty), reducing anxiety and creating a 'peace-of-mind' effect. Although P&C insurance is often seen only as a basic protection tool, it is a critical health and wealth preservation technique. It **shields your assets, including houses and businesses**, from losses that can wipe out years of savings and derail long-term plans. With small, predictable premium payments, unpredictable, high-loss events can be hedged to support stable cash flow and long-term wealth preservation.

Insurance, in any form, reduces volatility and improves investors' financial resilience.

Preventive health strategies

Preventive health strategies can mitigate health risks while also reframing the approach to wealth. A McKinsey Health Institute paper found that investors who consider proactive wellness and health strategies tend to be more confident in financial/legacy planning:

- Advanced technologies such as predictive analytics, next-gen genomic sequencing and IoT-enabled wearables are leading the transformation **from a reactive to a proactive** approach towards healthcare. **Genomic testing** identifies health risks and predicts disease likelihood, guiding early diagnosis. **Wearables** deliver real-time data for continuous monitoring, early detection and personalised preventive care. These approaches can support precision medicine, better physical activity, cardiovascular health and diabetes management.
- Organisations are including **preventive programmes** as they can reduce healthcare costs and claims significantly. For example, Cleveland Clinic's employee wellness initiative saved its healthcare system approximately USD 180m by enabling employees to reach eight preventive health targets (including stress management, healthy BMI and annual primary-care visits). Savings free up more capital for long-term goals such as retirement and investments.
- Proactive health and wellness strategies help to protect the primary wealth engine, i.e., **human capital**. The Cleveland Clinic study also showed that healthy individuals could reduce their chronic-disease risk by nearly 90% through preventive strategies, thereby strengthening their long-term capacity to work. **Career longevity** could translate to higher earnings and preserve income streams.
- With reduced risk profiles owing to preventive care, investors generally pay lower premiums and premium increases are slower. A study indicated that individuals under preventive care programmes are able to reduce premiums roughly worth USD 1,600 per family. This **reduced cash outflow** helps households maintain steady investing habits.

Wellness-centred living

Wellness-centred living refers to homes, communities and neighbourhoods that are intentionally designed to support physical, mental and emotional well-being. **Clean air, natural light, low toxicity and noise, and an active lifestyle** are some key features of such health environments. The Global Wellness Institute (GWI) identifies wellness-centred communities as the next frontier of growth for the wellness industry. Wellness real estate has been growing at 19.5% annually, nearly 4x faster than traditional real estate.

GWI assessed clinical and building-environment data and found that improved health environments contributed to better health outcomes. Buyers are increasingly seeking **sustainable and health-forward environments**, a trend that supports premium willingness-to-pay for homes with superior air quality, natural light and biophilic design. Growing buyer preference, faster absorption and category outperformance indicate that wellness properties tend to hold value better and have better liquidity than traditional properties.

The rise of longevity economy

Longevity economy refers to the economic value generated by individuals aged 50 and above – a segment that is increasingly becoming a major contributor to GDP, employment and income across 76 economies. By 2050, senior citizens may account for nearly 26% of the world's population, underscoring the scale of this shift.

Employment, entrepreneurship, investments and consumption patterns are largely shaped by longer life expectancy. There is a growing need and opportunity to rejig wealth portfolios to align them with longer lives and health spans. Investing in wellness and healthcare becomes critical for investors who want to remain productive and continue accumulating wealth well into their later years.

In short, the longevity economy is about the economic power of longer, healthier and more productive lives that continue to accumulate and preserve wealth.

Key drivers of the longevity economy

Source: Standard Chartered

Investment opportunities

As longer health spans shift focus to preventive care and digital wellness, investments aligned with this new reality can add significant value to investor portfolios and make them more resilient.

Some prominent investment options for sophisticated investors include:

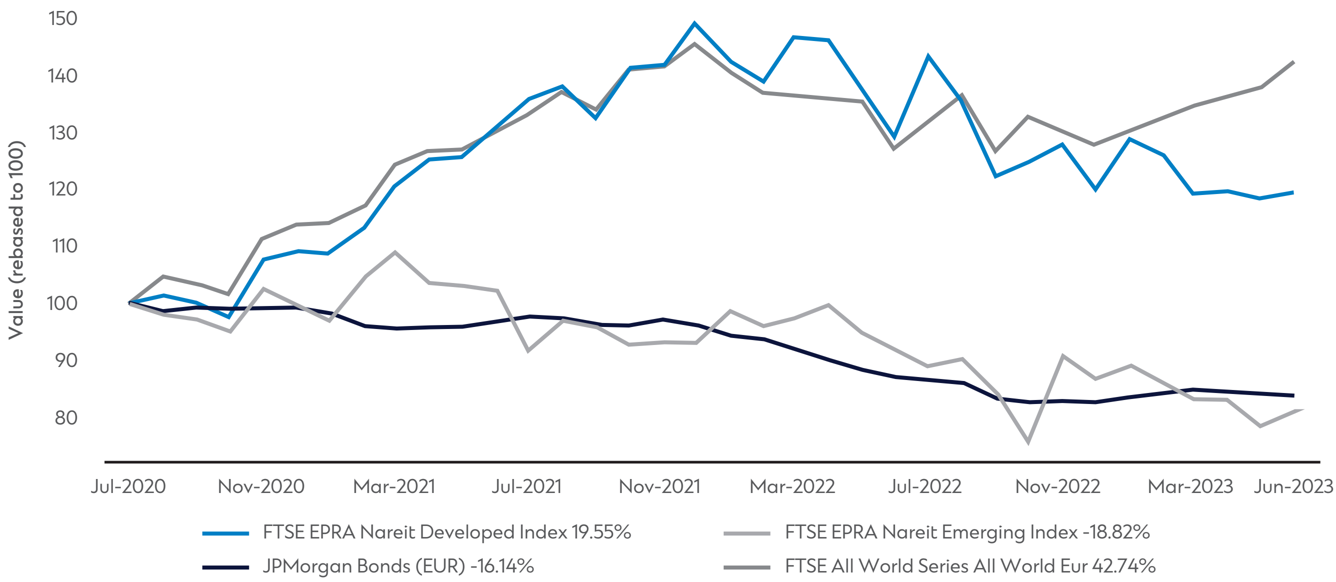
Healthcare real estate investment trusts (REITs)

Healthcare real estate investment trusts (REITs) own, lease or finance health-anchored properties such as medical centres, hospitals and wellness-aligned facilities. The income is typically in the form of inflation-adjusted lease/rental income or interest payments on the loans extended. These assets sit at the core of the fast-growing wellness real estate market. As life and health spans increase, demand for rehabilitative care, medical services and wellness-centred properties rises. Investing in healthcare REITs can capture this need-based, non-cyclical demand, offering a wide range of benefits to complex portfolios, such as:

- **Inflation-adjusted, stable income streams from rentals/leases**: The demand often remains steady across economic cycles, and the contractual agreements for properties are typically long term, offering investors clear visibility into cash flow. Dividend payouts from REITs (often mandatory) offer regular cashflows for investors, enhancing liquidity and income stability considerably in complex portfolios.

- **Healthcare REITs bear low correlation with traditional assets:** This asset class provides meaningful diversification to a portfolio. Real estate, in general, moves differently in magnitude, timing and trend compared to traditional portfolios. Healthcare REITs often respond more slowly to changing undercurrents than equities and bonds.

Global real estate vs equities and bonds – Total returns (EUR) rolling 36 months performance



Source: Standard Chartered, EPRA

- **Downside protection:** Healthcare REITs derive revenue from hospitals, senior housing and medical offices – essential services that tend to deliver a defensive performance during economic downturns.

Thematic investing and early-stage funding

Thematic investing and early-stage funding in the health and wellness space can also be promising additions to complex portfolios:

- **Senior living platforms/spaces, assisted-living development financing, longevity biotech, rehabilitation technology, mobility devices and remote monitoring** look promising in this space. Publicly listed opportunities are currently limited, but sophisticated investors can consider using the private equity route to explore opportunities in this space.
- Governments are shifting spend towards preventive healthcare, diagnostics and early detection. This suggests **sustained growth of at-home diagnostics platforms, precision screening and preventive care clinics**. Early-stage funding opportunities in metabolic health and healthy ageing innovations can be considered.
- Rising awareness around mental/emotional health is expected to pave the way for **behavioural health platforms, tele-therapy solutions, sleep tech and neurotech** investment options. This segment is in its nascent stages, which may present early-stage funding opportunities.

Venture philanthropy

Venture philanthropy in the health and well-being space can also be explored. It combines venture capital (VC) principles with philanthropy for social good. The healthy ageing funding gap (the mismatch between low funding and increased demand for ageing-related services, such as senior care and community wellness infrastructure) de-risks the venture philanthropy route. The affordable and community wellness segment remains underfunded despite enormous demand. Similarly, non-commercial capital is essential to support health-conscious environments in low-income and rural communities. Several ventures in this space tend to have low initial financial returns but high social returns, making them viable targets for venture philanthropy.

Health and wellness in legacy planning

A health and wellness-aligned legacy plan protects and ensures a seamless wealth transition while nurturing a culture of wellness stewardship for future generations. Let's look at some key strategies that can help draft a comprehensive legacy plan:

Long-term care directives (LTCDs) traditionally focused on end-of-life care and power of attorney when the principal (the person who creates the directive) becomes incapacitated. Modern-day directives are attuned to **extended life rather than end-of-life care**. Today, a comprehensive LTCD would include:

- Lifestyle-appropriate care for healthy ageing and not only terminal care. Active ageing needs, such as mobility assistance, precision nutrition, longevity coaching and therapy, are now laid out in LTCDs.
- Directives on preventive care, early intervention and health optimisation (e.g., regular biomarker screening, precision health programmes and wearables) are documented to ensure proactive, personalised health stewardship aligned with the individual's evolving goals and values.
- Mental and emotional well-being are seen as critical aspects for improved quality of life; LTCDs now include mental well-being guidelines, such as therapy access, social-connection preferences, sleep and neuro therapies.

As **digital health integration and wearables** grow more prevalent, sophisticated investors face the increasing risk of **data leaks** that could harm their reputation. Explicit provisions around data rights, storage and sharing to ensure robust cyber protection over time are now actively pursued in legacy planning. Trusted advocate roles may need to be established that allow family members to easily access and share their health records with providers while ensuring confidentiality.

Family governance frameworks are now embedded with health and wellness details to **maintain the quality of financial choices, reduce family conflicts and protect long-term wealth**. Annual family health reviews, financial-wellness dashboards, early detection and intervention directives can ensure that the family remains financially resilient and less prone to crisis-driven financial decisions. Formalising rules to prevent major financial decisions during illness, burnout or cognitive overload ensure decisions are of optimal quality across generations.

Elaborate funding frameworks are included to **standardise protocol on handling longevity and well-being** across generations. Fund allocation towards assisted living, preventive care and digital therapeutics are outlined. Guardrails on liquidity are included to avoid any forced asset liquidation during extended care needs.

Wellness literacy is incorporated into beneficiary education initiatives to ensure that the younger generation understands its health data rights and behavioural guardrails in financial decision-making and inculcates wellness stewardship.

Emerging trends in the holistic wealth space

Investors are considering health and wellness as a strategic financial asset capable of extending earning capacity, improving decision-making, protecting savings and reducing unplanned portfolio liquidation or withdrawals.

A stable health profile allows disciplined investing and uninterrupted compounding of wealth. It is important to stay up to date on the emerging trends in the holistic wealth space to stay agile and adaptive in your wealth journey. Some of the key trends that are redefining this space are:

Health insurance is shifting from a claims-only model to a proactive ecosystem that includes preventive care, mental health support, digital health analytics and wellness coaching. Integrated wellness insurance and preventive interventions are proving to be financially accretive.

Insurance and other techniques to handle health shocks have measurable mental and emotional health benefits. Improved mental and emotional health can lead to rational money decisions and is now seen as a wealth preservation factor.

Wearables and health analytics are integrated into financial planning and risk assessment to support personalised mental/emotional coaching and reduced medical cost. Real-time health data is becoming a tool for hyper-personalising wealth advice and risk management.

Wellness-centred real estate is becoming a mainstream investment option. It is seen as a long-term health stabiliser and value accelerator. Sustainable and biophilic designs have become financial variables, as health-engineered environments reduce health risk, enhance productivity and preserve wealth.

It’s time for an integrated approach

All the available data points to the fact that investors are increasingly recognising health and wellness as key components of holistic wealth management. This has resulted in systemic shifts in the financial planning and investing landscape. Homes with clear air, natural light, low toxicity and green access are being pursued for their potential to contribute to overall wellness and financial stability. Insurance is seeing an evident shift from being a claims-driven coverage to offering preventive care, mental and emotional support, telemedicine access and health analytics, which enables tailored advice and risk management. Wearables and real time health data are helping improve investors’ overall well-being and financial behaviour.

As the link between wealth and health strengthens, investors who follow a holistic and integrated approach are likely to build the most resilient portfolios.

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